



ST. PIUS X CATHOLIC HIGH SCHOOL · MODEL UN CONFERENCE 2026

GENERAL ASSEMBLY COUNCIL

Rehabilitation and Reintegration of Child Soldiers

Adela Ntardzenyuy & Clark Sanders, Chairs

GA/BG/2026

Background: UN General Assembly Hall, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 2.0

Table of Contents

01 Letter from the Chairs

02 Key Terms

03 Introduction

04 Historical Background

05 Challenges

06 Questions to Consider

07 Further Research

08 Works Cited

Letter from the Chairs

Welcome to the 2026 St. Pius X Model United Nations Conference hosted by St. Pius X Catholic High School. Our team is delighted to introduce our commitment for this year's SPX Conference, the General Assembly Council (GA). This year's committee chairs are Clark Sanders and Adela Ntardzenyuy. Adela Ntardzenyuy is in her last year of high school; she is secretary of St. Pius X's Diverse Student Union and co-captain of their debate team. This is her first year chairing, but she has attended numerous Model UN conferences, including the National High School Model UN Conference in New York. Clark Sanders is a senior at St. Pius X Catholic High School and is also co-captain of the Debate team. He has attended a couple of conferences and enjoys developing his skills in public speaking and collaboration. Outside of the classroom, he works as a lifeguard. They are both very excited to meet and work with all of y'all.

The topic on the agenda for this committee is rehabilitation and reintegration of child soldiers.

This background guide serves as an introduction to this committee's topic. However, it is not intended to replace individual research. In preparation for this conference, each delegation must submit a one-page position paper on the topic to antardzenyuy27@spxstudent.org and csanders27@spxstudent.org by 11:59 p.m. on the due date. In addition, this conference strictly follows the National Model United Nations (NMUN) rules of procedure. This includes following the position paper guidelines as set out in the Position Paper Guide and the NMUN·NY Position Papers Website. The NMUN Rules of Procedure themselves can be found under the Prepare for Committee section on the NMUN website. Please familiarize yourself with these resources, explained in detail below, as they will be essential for structuring the flow of the conference.

The NMUN Delegate Preparation Guide, which explains each step in the delegate process, from preconference research to the committee debate and resolution drafting process.

The NMUN Rules of Procedure, which include the long and short forms of the rules, as well as an explanatory narrative and example script of the flow of procedure.

We want to emphasize that any instances of sexual harassment or discrimination based on race, gender, sexual orientation, national origin, religion, age, or disability will not be tolerated. We wish you all the best in your preparations and look forward to seeing you at the conference.

Adela Ntardzenyuy & Clark Sanders, Chairs

Key Terms

Child associated with an armed force or armed group. A person under 18 who is recruited or used by an armed force or armed group in any capacity, including as fighters, cooks, messengers, spies, or for other purposes.

Rehabilitation. The process of providing medical, psychological, educational, and other support to help children recover from their experiences and prepare to return to civilian life.

Reintegration. The process through which children return to civilian life and develop meaningful roles and identities within their families and communities.

Psychosocial support. Support that addresses children's psychological and social well-being after experiencing conflict, violence, or displacement.

Re-recruitment. The recruitment of a child who has previously been released from an armed force or armed group. Preventing re-recruitment is a major goal of reintegration programs.

Introduction

According to the United Nations Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, a child soldier is defined as a child associated with an armed force or armed group, referring to any person under the age of 18 who is or has been recruited or used by an armed force or armed group in any capacity, including but not limited to children used as fighters, cooks, spies, or for sexual purposes. Child soldiers are not limited to fighting; they can also act as messengers or even suicide bombers. Each year, the UN receives reports of child soldiers as young as 8 years old. Child soldiers are victims often subjected to abuse, sexual violence, and witnessing deaths and killings.

The United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund plays a critical role in reintegrating former child soldiers, with their primary goal being to prepare them for a return to civilian life. The Paris Principles define reintegration as “the process through which children transition into civil ... society and enter meaningful roles and identities as civilians who are accepted by their families and communities in a context of local and national reconciliation” (The Paris Principles). The overall focus of reintegration of children in the armed forces is returning them to their civilian lives and preventing the re-recruitment of child soldiers from happening again.

KEY TERM: RE-RECRUITMENT

The recruitment of a child who has previously been released from an armed force or armed group. Preventing re-recruitment is a central goal of reintegration programs.

A vital aspect of reintegration programs is psychosocial support, education, and/or training. This arduous process requires extensive support from the international community, beginning with negotiating the release of children and physically removing them from armed groups. In the Goma transitional care program in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC), children are first placed in UNICEF-supported transitional care; however, individualized support can be difficult to provide because of limited resources. UNICEF and its NGO partners must operate within these limitations while providing rehabilitation that is both expensive and time-consuming. Afterwards, children are returned to their communities. Some children may have lost contact with their families or lack the resources and support necessary to sustain themselves. The process of family reunification is therefore a laborious and resource-intensive effort. There is also the challenge of reintegration into communities, particularly when former child soldiers may have been forced to participate in violence against members of their own communities.

A main component within UNICEF's rehabilitation and re-integration efforts is encouraging life skills and economic autonomy by supporting vocational training or school enrollment. These activities often take place in local communities that also have vulnerable children to promote a sense of community and limit the stigmatization they might face after leaving the armed forces.

04

Historical Background

In 1989, world leaders made a historic decision to protect the rights of children everywhere. The Convention on the Rights of the Child is the most widely ratified human rights treaty in history, with 196 States parties. The Convention defines a child as any person under the age of 18. The Convention influenced governments to have better healthcare programs and nutritional goods for children, as well as more safeguards to protect kids from violence and exploitation. The human rights treaty is currently being monitored by the Committee on the Rights of the Child.

In 2000, the United Nations adopted two Optional Protocols to the Convention, including the Optional Protocol on the Involvement of Children in Armed Conflict (OPAC), which strengthened international protections against the recruitment and use of children in armed conflict.

UNICEF in 2014 started the “We are Children, Not Soldiers” campaign to bring global awareness to the topic as well as generate international support against child soldiers. The campaign received support from NGO partners, the UN, and the general public. Two years later, the campaign ended, but they continued their efforts by working with several countries through action plans and commitments to end the recruitment and use of children by national security forces.

While the campaign brought international attention to the issue, it could not end child recruitment on its own. It required countries to implement legislation and to cooperate with the United Nations.

The Children, Not Soldiers program influenced individual governments to take action to prevent the recruitment of child soldiers. For example, in 2011, Afghanistan signed an Action Plan with the United Nations as well as adopting a 15-point Road Map to Compliance three years later. In 2015, they criminalized the recruitment of children by their national security force.

Similarly, Chad has also put in place all the necessary measures to curb the recruitment of children in armed forces. They signed an Action plan with the UN, and by the end of 2014 they had fulfilled its requirements and are no longer listed as a violation in the annexes of the Annual Report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict.

Since the start of the campaign, other countries have started to work towards ending the recruitment of child soldiers. The Democratic Republic of Congo, Yemen, Myanmar, South Sudan, and Somalia started working with the UN through action plans aimed at ending and preventing the use of children in armed forces. Somalia established measures within its armed forces to strengthen child protections and facilitate the transfer of child soldiers to the UN.

While Sudan was among the targeted countries by the Children, Not Soldiers campaign, they were still negotiating their action plan with the UN at the start of the campaign. Showing that progress towards ending the recruitment of child soldiers is not happening at the same pace in every country and can take many years of negotiation.

05

Challenges

Rehabilitating and reintegrating child soldiers is a very complex issue that extends far beyond removing the children from these armed groups. Although there is broad international agreement that child soldiers should be protected and supported, significant challenges remain in terms of how rehabilitation should be provided, who should fund these programs, and how governments should address accountability for crimes committed while in the armed forces.

Successful reintegration requires more than the physical removal of a child from an armed group; former child soldiers may need medical care, psychosocial support, education, family reunification, vocational training, and assistance in rebuilding relationships within their communities. Rehabilitation programs must account for their age and individual circumstances because they are still developing mentally and emotionally.

Measuring successful reintegration can be challenging because returning a child to their community doesn't necessarily mean that the process is completed. Family acceptance, access to education, psychosocial support, life and vocational skills, community acceptance, and long-term assistance can all contribute to successful reintegration. Providing educational opportunities and mentors can help create alternatives to returning to armed groups; however, these services can be challenging to maintain over an extended period, especially in communities already affected by poverty and conflict.

Another challenge is determining how to address accountability when it comes to child soldiers who have participated in acts of violence. Children may be victims of recruitment and exploitation while also participating in crimes during their time with an armed group, creating a difficult balance between protecting children's rights and supporting their rehabilitation while also addressing the harms experienced by victims and communities. Approaches may include prosecution in appropriate circumstances, amnesty, restorative justice, or community-based reconciliation, but can vary depending on the child's age, individual circumstances, the nature of the acts committed, and the legal framework of the country.

Rehabilitation programs face the challenges of supporting former child soldiers while also addressing the needs and concerns of the communities that they will return to. Communities find it difficult to accept former child soldiers because of significant losses during the conflict.

FUNDING GAP

Over five years, around 55,000 children were released from armed groups or forces, while only 70 percent of them could receive reintegration care.

Funding is a significant challenge for rehabilitation and reintegration programs for child soldiers. These programs can require resources for psychosocial support, education, family tracing and reunification, vocational training, and community-based services. Deciding who should bear the cost can be challenging, especially in countries whose governments have limited resources or whose infrastructure has been affected by conflict. Reintegration is a long process and continued support is necessary; however, assisting for several years requires sustained financial commitments from governments and international organizations. Limited or short-term funding can make it difficult for programs to provide consistent support to children throughout the reintegration process.

Children associated with armed groups may have different rehabilitative needs depending on their experiences during recruitment and their time with armed groups. Girls may face particular challenges, including sexual violence, exploitation, pregnancy, and difficulties accessing appropriate health and reintegration services. Boys may also experience forms of violence and exploitation that require specialized support. Rehabilitation programs must balance providing equal protection for all children with addressing the individual and gender-specific needs of those returning to civilian life.

Preventing the re-recruitment of former child soldiers is another major challenge. Children may remain vulnerable to recruitment when they return to communities affected by conflict, poverty, displacement, or limited educational and economic opportunities. If former child soldiers lack access to education, employment, family support, or other forms of assistance, they may have difficulty establishing a stable civilian life. Rehabilitation programs must therefore address not only the immediate needs of children leaving armed groups but also the conditions that could make them vulnerable to recruitment again.

06

Questions to Consider

1. How can child soldiers be safely removed from armed groups they are in while limiting the risk of re-recruitment?
2. Who should be responsible for funding rehabilitation programs?
3. How should programs provide appropriate psychosocial and trauma support to former child soldiers?
4. How should governments address the crimes committed by children in armed groups while protecting their rights and supporting reintegration?
5. How can former child soldiers be reunited with their families, and what programs should respond when family reunification is not possible?
6. How can rehabilitation programs promote community acceptance and reduce stigma toward former child soldiers?
7. How can the UN monitor whether countries are actually implementing reintegration programs?
8. How can programs address poverty, lack of education, and limited economic opportunities that may increase the risk of re-recruitment?
9. How can former child soldiers regain access to education after leaving armed groups, particularly when they have missed years of schooling?

Further Research

- Al Jazeera Staff, "Yemen's Reignited War Fuels a New Wave in Child Recruitment," Al Jazeera, 8 Sept. 2026.
- "Child Soldiers | Research Starters | EBSCO Research," EBSCO, 2024.
- "Growing Concern Over Child Soldiers in Iran," IranWire, 8 Sept. 2026.
- Grønhaug, Kristine. "Child Soldiers." Norwegian Refugee Council, 2013.
- Misic, Lidija. "Child Soldiers." Humanium, 31 Dec. 2016.
- Singer, Peter W. "Children at War." Brookings, Sept. 2002.
- UNICEF. "Children Recruited by Armed Forces or Armed Groups." UNICEF, 3 Sept. 2020.

Works Cited

Affairs, International. "How Reintegration Processes Fail Child Soldiers." International Affairs Blog, 6 July 2023, medium.com/international-affairs-blog/how-reintegration-processes-fail-child-soldiers-9c2f87dbba96.

"Chad Commits to an Acceleration of the Action Plan to End the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers." Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, 2026, childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/chad-commits-to-an-acceleration-of-the-action-plan-to-end-the-recruitment-and-use-of-child-soldiers.

Financing Support for Child Reintegration Issues and Options Study.
childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/sites/default/files/2021/07/Financing-Support-for-Child-Reintegration.pdf. Accessed 13 Sept. 2026.

"Healing Child Soldiers." Bulletin of the World Health Organization, vol. 87, no. 5, May 2009, pp. 330–31.

Ladue, Mikaylah, et al. Child-Inclusive and Gender-Responsive Reintegration Programmes.
lisd.princeton.edu/sites/g/files/toruqf506/files/documents/gender_paper_caac-lisd_7-3_-_final_0.pdf. Accessed 13 Sept. 2026.

Mayer, Alexis. "Rehabilitation of Child Soldiers in Somalia." International Law and Policy Brief, 18 Feb. 2021,
studentbriefs.law.gwu.edu/ilpb/2021/02/18/rehabilitation-of-child-soldiers-in-somalia/.

"Reintegrating Children as a Contribution to Peace and Security." Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, 2018, childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/reintegrating-children-as-a-contribution-to-peace-and-security.

"Release and Reintegration." Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, 2025,
childrenandarmedconflict.un.org/en/release-and-reintegration.

"Research Guides: Convention on the Rights of the Child (1989) 35th Anniversary: Optional Protocols to the Convention on the Rights of the Child." UN.org, 2014, research.un.org/c.php?g=1331357&p=10072557.

Save the Children. "UN Convention on the Rights of the Child." [Savethechildren.org.uk](https://www.savethechildren.org.uk), 2011, www.savethechildren.org.uk/what-we-do/childrens-rights/united-nations-convention-of-the-rights-of-the-child.

UNICEF. The Paris Principles and Guidelines on Children Associated with Armed Forces or Armed Groups. 2007,
www.unicef.org/mali/media/1561/file/ParisPrinciples.pdf.